

Prof. Simon Mayer
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Prof. Ola Svensson
Chair of the Search Committee
École Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne

St.Gallen, October 31, 2025

Subject: Application for a Faculty Position in Computer & Communication Sciences

Dear Prof. Svensson, Dear Members of the Search Committee:

My name is Simon Mayer and I am writing to apply for the position of Full Professorship in Computer & Communication Sciences at EPFL. I currently hold a Full Professorship of Computer Science with a specialization in Interaction- and Communication-based Systems at the University of St.Gallen, Switzerland. My main research areas are Ubiquitous Computing and Multiagent Systems, with a focus on interfaces between people, agents, and artifacts.

In addition to building up my own research group at the University of St.Gallen over the past seven years, I have been one of the four founding professors of the Computer Science department at my current university. In this role, I significantly contributed to the conceptualization, design, implementation, and delivery of PhD (2019), M.Sc. (2021; reform 2024), and B.Sc. (2022) programs in Entrepreneurial Computer Science—the programs integrate technical Computer Science with skills and acumen for business, thereby leveraging St.Gallen’s setup as a business school for a societally-oriented Computer Science. I was directly responsible for key decisions on program structure, recruitment of ten further professors and lecturers, regulatory setup, and institutional, political, cultural, and legal embedding. I have furthermore been the managing director of the Institute of Computer Science at the University of St.Gallen from its inception in the year 2019 until the year 2024. In February 2024, I assumed the position of Dean of the Computer Science department. During my time at the University of St.Gallen, we grew our department to ten research groups with over 120 employees and our study programs from 0 to almost 300 students, thereby putting the university on track to reach its political objectives with respect to Computer Science qualitatively, quantitatively, and below allocated budget.

I consider this build-up task as well-accomplished and am stepping down as Dean in February 2026 to focus more on my research projects. While I am proud of the achievements of my research group over the past years, I can see that many of our ideas and projects now touch their natural limit at a university whose focus lies more on core business aspects than on the advancement of technological and scientific understanding. I have hence been seeking an opportunity that would align better with my interests and where I could contribute more towards that objective; this is what I perceive to be offered with EPFL.

With respect to research, my long-term goal is to contribute to advancing interoperability and autonomy in ubiquitous computing environments by conceptualizing ideal interfaces between people, autonomous agents, and artifacts in their surroundings. This endeavor started with my PhD work and its application in the context of a position as a senior key expert with Siemens Corporate Technology, which have significantly contributed to the establishment of the World Wide Web and its architecture as an application-layer integration point for Internet of Things environments: the Web of Things. My work is today reflected in the W3C Web of Things

standards, which have been instrumental to take us closer to creating scalable yet flexible smart environments for people and machines, and which are today implemented across products in industrial manufacturing, building automation, and beyond—including resource-constrained devices. For me, this work created an opportunity to integrate technologies from the research domains of Distributed Systems, Multiagent Systems, and the Human-Computer Interaction field that I decided to pursue further, first towards the integration of multiagent- and logic-based AI planning for flexibly integrating Web-based industrial equipment (e.g., manufacturing robots) according to a defined production goal and today towards an integration of ecological psychology with this line of research to include humans as well as diverse artificial agents. This work hence represents a bridging between the Web of Things, AI Agents research, and Human-Computer Interaction, and it ideally fits to my core fascination with Computer Science – the field of Ubiquitous Computing. It is reflected in my research group’s publication profile across corresponding prime venues (CHI, IMWUT, AAMAS) as well as in my own editorial profile in the Ubiquitous Computing and Pervasive Computing fields. While bringing my international network of collaborators to EPFL, I would hence enjoy direct disciplinary exchange and collaboration with researchers in the CHILI Lab, the Immersive Interaction Research Group, the REACT Group, several of EPFL’s robotics labs, and beyond (please see my research statement for details).

My positioning in the Ubiquitous Computing field is also representative of my belief that we today need to assert and protect Computer Science as a discipline that responsibly exerts an ever-increasing influence on society. As Computer Science researchers, we should contribute to solving core Computer Science problems, but in addition consider the societal effects these advancements might have: It is not only important how novelty can be *accomplished*, but also how its *context might be shaped*—sometimes accepting constraints—to serve society. A tangible example of my conviction to this ideal is that research with legal scholars has led to me accepting a recent invitation to join the European oversight board on Very Large Online Platform auditing, to my knowledge as the only Computer Scientist. My stance towards societal effects of Computer Science has also led to my demonstrated motivation, commitment, and ability to work cross-disciplinarily beyond the Computer Science domain, which has been explicitly acknowledged by colleagues in Law (Prof. Aurelia Tamò-Larriex, University of Lausanne), Sociology (Prof. Tanja Schneider, Denmark Technical University), and Human Nutrition (Prof. Lia Bally, University Hospital Bern) and is documented in joint publications and projects. I find it important—and highly stimulating—to seek deep understanding of each other’s domain rather than accepting superficial alignment and argue that such mutual understanding – while costly at first – brings major insights when it is accomplished.

I have been able to drive my and my group’s disciplinary and cross-disciplinary projects through a strong funding strategy that has led to my direct involvement as PI or Co-PI in 4 SNSF, 2 Innosuisse, 2 EU, and over a dozen industry and foundation projects (total 3.9 MCHF allocated to my group out of a total of 13.6 MCHF) in my current position over the past 6 years. This has been instrumental to my group build-up and successes despite my current positioning at a university that still has little visibility in the Computer Science field and where the attraction of highly talented PhD students is an ongoing concern.

My view of Computer Science as a societal core field also shapes my great enjoyment of teaching, where my portfolio stretches from introductory Computer Science, Computer Networks, and Distributed Systems courses to specialized courses in advanced systems engineering and in Ubiquitous Computing (please see my teaching statement for details). Stimulated by the motivating experience and positive feedback when supporting the teaching of undergraduate and graduate courses already since my own B.Sc. studies, I worked for and obtained a postgraduate degree in secondary and higher education from ETH Zurich in 2014. The didactics skills I gained have been valuable when supervising students, in outreach events, during teaching internships and in current joint projects with schools, and for my university teaching as main instructor at UC Berkeley (2015-2016), ETH Zurich (2016-2017), Massachusetts Institute of Technology (2017), Graz University of Technology (2017), University of Zurich (2021-2022), University of Bologna (2023), and of course at the University of St.Gallen (since 2018). I enjoy teaching introductory courses, seeing them as a chance to

sustainably shape the perspective of young students on Computer Science; and I am proud that my courses receive very positive student feedback and evaluations, and that I had been nominated as a finalist for the Best Teaching Award at my university, despite my courses being perceived as content-dense, effortful, and “hard”.

With this profile, I would very much enjoy continuing my career with EPFL. I believe that a Faculty Position at EPFL would give me the opportunity to continue my research in Ubiquitous Computing and at the intersection of core Computer Science, its applications, and society. And I expect that EPFL and its community would benefit from my combination of academic and industrial expertise, timely research directions, deep interdisciplinarity, extensive international teaching experience, international professional network, positive attitude, and high base motivation and energy.

Please find attached my Curriculum Vitae, Research Statement, Teaching Statement, Publication List, and the contact details of seven potential referees. I will be happy to provide you by email or telephone with any further information you might require, and look forward to hearing from you.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, consisting of several fluid, overlapping strokes that form a stylized representation of the name Simon Mayer.

Prof. Simon Mayer